Crime-Scene Documentation and Evidence Custody

CRIMINOLOGIST · criminal-justice-foundations · BoardPrep lesson v1

Official examination scope

The PRC enhanced Criminology TOS defines licensure competencies; consult its current annex for exact boundaries. This lesson teaches scene documentation, evidence preservation, and custody records using NIJ guidance. It does not estimate item frequency or replace applicable Philippine law and agency procedures.

Learning objectives

- Preserve scene context and record observable conditions before collection changes them.
- Trace an item's identity, recovery, condition, package, seal, and transfers.
- Distinguish a custody-record gap from proof that evidence was altered.

1. Secure, observe, and document

Protect people first and control access so the scene is not unnecessarily disturbed. Record the condition on arrival and the relationship between traces and their surroundings. Notes, photographs, measurements, and sketches preserve different details. Separate direct observations from later interpretations.

2. Preserve context before collection

A trace can lose meaning if its location or relationship to other objects is undocumented. Record and photograph it in context, then collect it using the approved method. When evidence is vulnerable to weather or loss, protect it promptly while assigning parallel tasks where staffing allows. Follow agency and laboratory guidance for packaging and preservation.

3. Maintain custody continuity

Give each item a unique identifier and record its description, condition, recovery location, date and time, collector, package, and seal. Each transfer should identify the giver, receiver, date and time, and purpose, with a receipt or secure electronic record. If an authorized examination opens a package, document the event and replacement seal under policy.

4. Review gaps without overclaiming

An unexplained broken seal or incomplete resealing entry is a traceability problem requiring investigation. The record alone does not establish who caused the gap or whether an item changed. Preserve the original record, seek authorized explanations and corroboration, and report any unresolved limitation accurately.

Review an incomplete reseal record

Question: A laboratory log says an exhibit was opened for testing and resealed, but the replacement seal has no initials or date. What can the reviewer conclude?
1. Identify the missing initials and date as a documentation gap.
2. Check authorized laboratory records, transfer receipts, and the examiner's account for an explanation.
3. Do not call the gap tampering unless independent evidence supports that conclusion.
Answer: The resealing event is insufficiently documented and requires explanation and corroboration.
Check: The conclusion preserves the evidentiary concern without claiming a proven alteration.

Common misconceptions

- Collecting before recording location can remove useful scene context.
- A label alone is not a complete record of every transfer.
- A broken or incomplete seal entry is not by itself proof of tampering.

- Guidance must be applied with local law, agency policy, safety, and laboratory requirements.

Practice patterns

- Choose what to document or protect first when a scene feature may change.
- Identify missing information in a collection, transfer, opening, or resealing record.
- Separate a supportable custody conclusion from an unsupported accusation.

Official scope references

Official scope: Enhanced Tables of Specifications for the Licensure Examination for Criminologists — Professional Regulation Commission; Professional Regulatory Board of Criminology — https://www.prc.gov.ph/sites/default/files/2024-02%20Published%20%281%29%20%281%29.pdf

Instructional references

Instructional reference: Crime Scene Investigation: A Guide for Law Enforcement — National Institute of Justice / National Forensic Science Technology Center — https://nij.ojp.gov/library/publications/crime-scene-investigation-guide-law-enforcement
Instructional reference: Crime Scene Investigation: Guides for Law Enforcement — National Institute of Justice — https://nij.ojp.gov/topics/articles/crime-scene-investigation-guides-law-enforcement
Instructional reference: Collecting DNA Evidence at Property Crime Scenes: Chain of Custody — National Institute of Justice, U.S. Department of Justice — https://nij.ojp.gov/nij-hosted-online-training-courses/collecting-dna-evidence-at-property-crime-scenes/evidence-collection/chain-custody

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No claim about question frequency or examination weighting is made.